

Nikita Obraztsov

Saint Petersburg, Russia | nikobrazets@gmail.com | nikitaobraztsov.com

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Agent-based modeling · social network analysis · secularization dynamics · computational methods in religious studies · AI and religious belief systems · network resilience

EDUCATION

MA, Computational Social Sciences (exp. 2027)

European University at St. Petersburg

Supervisor: Prof. Evgeny Kotelnikov

MA, Religious Studies (*with distinction*, 2020)

St. Petersburg State University

Thesis: *The Brights Movement as a Phenomenon of Contemporary Culture*

Supervisor: Prof. Marianna Shakhnovich

BA, Law (*with distinction*, 2018)

Moscow State University of Law (MSAL)

CORE RESEARCH PROJECT

Network Topology as a Buffer Against Secularization: An Agent-Based Model (2025–2026)

Examines how cross-group network connectivity shapes long-run secularization dynamics using agent-based simulation on Stochastic Block Model graphs.

Key findings: Segregated communities preserve $6.6\times$ higher religiosity than integrated ones. Critical tipping point at $p_{cross} = 0.06\text{--}0.10$. Social support buffer identified as the dominant mechanism.

Technical implementation: Python 3.10 (NumPy, NetworkX, Pandas); Stochastic Block Model with systematic variation of cross-group connectivity; ablation study and sensitivity analysis; full reproducibility via SeedSequence and JSON config export.

Theory: Integrates existential security hypothesis (Inglehart 2020), bounded confidence dynamics (Deffuant et al. 2000), social support mechanisms (Stark & Finke 2000).

Code: github.com/nikobraztsov/abm-secularization (MIT License)

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

“Network Segregation as a Buffer Against Secularization: An Agent-Based Model”

- European Social Networks Conference (EUSN 2026), Norrköping, Sweden, June 2026 [*accepted; endorsed by INSNA*]
- Computational Social Science Conference (CSS 2026), St. Petersburg, April 2026

“Structural Limits of Religious Minority Resilience in Secular Society: An Agent-Based Modeling Approach”

- All-Russian Academic Conference “Studies of Religion: Past, Present, Future,” Russian Religious Studies Association, online, April 2026

“‘Belonging Without Believing’ in the Context of Orthodox Identity Formation in Russia”

- VII All-Russian Sociological Congress, Russian Society of Sociologists, Moscow, November 2025

“From Description to Explanation: Analytical Sociology as a Methodological Resource for Religious Studies”

- International Conference “Religious Studies in Tsarskoye Selo,” St. Petersburg, November 2025

“Computational Methods in Religious Studies: Effectiveness and Limits”

- VIII Congress of the Russian Religious Studies Society, Vladimir, October 2025

“The Popularity of Religious Chatbots as an Indicator of Religious Transformation”

- II International Conference “Artificial Intelligence and Spiritual Culture,” Plekhanov Russian University of Economics, Moscow, October 2025

PUBLICATIONS

Books

Obraztsov, N.A. (2024). *Religions of the World*. Moscow: Bombora/EKSMO, 208 p. ISBN 978-5-04-192309-9.
Orthodox Traditions and Holidays (forthcoming). Mann, Ivanov & Ferber. Under contract.

Articles

Obraztsov, N.A. (2025). “The Concept of Belonging Without Believing in the Context of Orthodox Identity Formation in Russia.” In: *Sociology and Society: Formation and Functioning of Social Memory. Proceedings of the VII All-Russian Sociological Congress*. Moscow. EDN QUINAN.

TECHNICAL COMPETENCIES

Python (proficient): ABM design, NumPy, NetworkX, Pandas; reproducibility tools (SeedSequence); statistical analysis

R (proficient): machine learning (tidymodels), visualization (ggplot2), causal inference (dagitty/ggdag), exploratory factor analysis, web scraping (rvest)

Network Analysis: Stochastic Block Model, ego-networks, structural metrics, Gephi

Tools: Git/GitHub, Zotero, Obsidian; WVS and ESS survey analysis; panel data methods

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

- Triple prize-winner, IV All-Russian Student Olympiad “Sociologist in the 21st Century” (2026): 3rd place individual ranking; Best Video Essay; Best VCIOM Analytics Report
- Winner, All-Russian Olympiad in Social Studies (VSOSH), national level, 2013

TEACHING & OUTREACH

Staff Lecturer, Pravoe Polusharie Introverta (2022–present): 100+ public lectures on world religions, secularization, religious AI, and contemporary religious transformations

LANGUAGES

Russian (native) · English (professional)